



A COURSE ON PAPER

All the Way Here.

**Bringing your attention back to the people and life already in
front of you.**

The Focus Protocol · Return · Lead · Keep

Write in it. Mark it up. Come back to it when life gets noisy.

WHAT IS INSIDE

The 72 hour Focus Protocol, nine lessons in three movements,
and room to write on every page. Use the online course for a quick read.
Use this book for the work.

START HERE

How it fits together.

There are four pieces, and each has one job. You do not need to finish any of them. You need to try a practice in a normal week and keep the ones that help.

01 The Focus Protocol

Three days, four small moves, before either of you asks the other to change anything. It is the start of this book and one sheet for the fridge.

02 The nine lessons

Three movements: Return, Lead, Keep. Each lesson is one idea and one practice. They are online for a quick read and in this book for the real work.

03 The Resource Pack

One sheet for each lesson, numbered to match it, plus the Sunday Board and a field card. Every sheet has a place it lives: the fridge, the glovebox, the nightstand.

04 The Sunday Board Meeting

Fifteen minutes a week at the table. It runs underneath everything else and is where the two of you decide what to keep.

The order

1 Start the Focus Protocol today

Do not make every boundary permanent on day one.

2 On day four, open Return

One lesson, one practice, tried during a normal week. Print that lesson's sheet.

3 Write here what actually happened

Not what should have happened.

4 End with the Thirty Day Page

Choose two practices to keep. Let the rest wait without guilt.

The promise you are making

I do not trade presence for distraction. My attention belongs to the people I share my life with. My phone is a tool. I am not.

START HERE · THE 72 HOUR FOCUS PROTOCOL

Control the inputs. Choose the attention.

Treat this as a short experiment in changing your surroundings. Reduce what pulls at you, add enough friction to notice the reflex, and make a different choice in everyday life. Nobody is testing your discipline.

01 Remove the color

Make the phone less visually demanding.

Switch the display to grayscale for the 72 hour experiment. Removing the color puts a small speed bump between the impulse and the tap.

Make it fit: Turn color back on when it is genuinely needed for work, maps, photos, health, or accessibility.

02 Control the feeds

Choose which inputs reach you during the reset.

Delete or sign out of the few apps you open without deciding. Keep essential tools. You are noticing the reflex. Nobody is asking you to live without a smartphone.

Make it fit: Use a browser or scheduled desktop window if an app is required for work or caregiving.

03 Silence the machine

Let people reach you without letting every platform interrupt you.

Turn off nonessential notifications. Keep priority calls, texts, medical alerts, authentication, and anything a caregiver truly needs.

Make it fit: Set navigation before the car moves and keep the phone out of your hand while driving. A notification is never worth a downward glance on the road.

04 Give the phone a home

Protect one repeated moment instead of policing the whole day.

Try a clear arrival rule: when you get home, the phone goes to one drawer, bag, or charging station instead of following you from room to room. If all evening is unrealistic, protect dinner, bedtime, a game, or the Sunday Board Meeting. Adults model the boundary first.

Make it fit: Allow priority contacts and tell people how to reach you. Shorten or move the window when work, health, accessibility, or caregiving requires it.

START HERE · WHAT THE 72 HOURS CAN FEEL LIKE

Know the hard part before you reach it.

0 to 6**The phantom reach**

Your hand goes to the pocket with no thought behind it. You will catch yourself unlocking a phone you had no reason to unlock. Nothing is wrong. You are simply meeting a habit you have never had to look at directly.

6 to 18**The boredom**

This is the hard part and it is the part most people quit in. Small gaps in the day that used to be filled are suddenly empty, and empty feels worse than it should. The urge to check will be strong and it will feel reasonable. It passes.

18 to 36**The settle**

The noise drops. Most people notice they are reaching less, that a task holds them longer, and that falling asleep gets easier. You did not fix yourself. There is just less arriving.

36 to 72**The room gets bigger**

Conversations run longer. You hear the second half of what someone says instead of the first half. The reflex is still there and it is quieter. This is the part worth keeping.

When the old habit starts negotiating

The seventy two hours end and your mind makes its case. It is persuasive, it sounds like you, and it shows up almost word for word.

“I have proven I can handle it now.”

“Just one app. Not the bad ones.”

“Ten minutes is not the same thing.”

“It was a busy week. This is not a normal test.”

Each of those is the habit asking for its old conditions back. Hold the arrangement for fourteen days before you change anything, and if an app comes back and the reaching starts again, run the seventy two hours once more. Think of it as collecting information.

If you are doing this together

If you are doing this with someone, say out loud which sentence you expect to hear from yourself. Naming it in advance makes it much harder to believe later, and it gives the other person something specific to ask about instead of policing you.



What did you notice when the phone stopped leading?

THE MOMENT I MOST OFTEN REACHED WITHOUT DECIDING

RETURN · LESSON 1.1

The Sanctuary

Get the open loops out of your head.

A familiar scene

The house is finally quiet, but your head is not. You remember the estimate while brushing your teeth, the school form when the lights go out, and the conversation you have been avoiding at 2:13 in the morning. Nothing is happening, yet your attention is still working overtime.

What is happening

Your body can be home while your mind is still carrying the estimate, the bill, the promise, the text, and the conversation you have been avoiding. The mind is useful for noticing and deciding. It is a poor place to store every unfinished thing.

The principle

Stop using your attention as a reminder system. Once it is written down, you can choose what needs action, a conversation, or letting go. The list does not have to be perfect.

The practice: A fifteen minute weekly mind sweep

Use paper, not your phone. Write until the page feels honest, then give the important items one next move.

01 Make four spaces

Label them Work, Home, Money and admin, and Me. Let an item appear in more than one place if that is how life feels.

02 Empty the loops

Write every task, promise, worry, idea, and avoided conversation. Do not organize while you write. When the list slows down, wait one minute and ask what you are still trying not to forget.

03 Mark the next move

Use D for Do, C for Choose, T for Talk, and R for Release. You do not need a full plan for every item.

04 Circle no more than three

Choose the few items that deserve attention this week. Bring only the shared items into the weekly conversation.



If fifteen minutes is unrealistic, use five. Miss a week without turning it into a failure. A useful ritual is one you can return to without shame.

Do the sweep separately, then trade only the items that touch both of you. Everything else stays yours. You're only trying to catch the four things you're both carrying and each assuming the other forgot.

The Brain Dump · Where it lives: The desk, or wherever you actually sit down. Print it from the Resource Pack and put it where the moment happens.

Tonight, put one sheet of paper in front of you and circle the single item that would make you more present tomorrow.

I built this because I was tired of being physically home while part of my attention was still somewhere else. The page does not make me a different person. It helps me come back to the life already in front of me.

What am I carrying in my head that belongs on paper, on a calendar, or in a conversation?

RETURN · LESSON 1.2

Focus Mode

Protect the work that changes something before maintenance takes the day.

A familiar scene

You answer messages, clear two small fires, tidy the inbox, and look up at 4:47. You were busy all day. The proposal, decision, call, or piece of work that would have changed something is still untouched, and now it is riding home with you.

What is happening

Maintenance work is necessary, visible, and endless. It can fill a whole day while the one thing that would move your work forward stays untouched. The unfinished target then follows you home.

The principle

Some work moves things forward. Some work keeps things running. Both matter. Do the first kind first, then tend the rest.

The practice: One protected target

Choose the target before reactive work begins, then give it a block that fits your actual day.

01 Choose it the night before

Write one sentence: Tomorrow matters if I finish _____. Make it concrete enough that you will know when it is done.

02 Choose a block that fits

Use 25, 50, or 90 minutes based on the work and the life around it. A protected half hour beats an imaginary perfect morning.

03 Close the obvious gates

Silence notifications, close email and messages, and put the phone out of reach unless the work genuinely requires it.

04 Then tend the rest

When the block ends, decide what maintenance matters now. Let that be your call, not the inbox's.

Make it fit

If your job is inherently reactive, protect the smallest block you can keep or choose one decision that must happen before the shift ends.



Tell each other the one sentence. Then when one of you is unreachable for ninety minutes, the other knows it was chosen and nobody took it.

Tomorrow Matters If · Where it lives: The desk, written the night before. Print it from the Resource Pack and put it where the moment happens.

Before bed, write tomorrow's one target and the exact time you will begin it.

I use this so I finish the right work and less of it rides home with me.

Which maintenance tasks make me feel productive while keeping me from the work that matters?

RETURN · LESSON 1.3

The Driveway Pause

Use the trip home as a deliberate transition.

A familiar scene

You pull into the driveway still replaying the last call. One more notification lights the screen. Inside, somebody has been waiting to tell you something ordinary and important. The first ten seconds can belong to the workday, or they can mark your arrival home.

What is happening

A commute can become an extension of work. Calls, messages, and mental rehearsals keep the body moving toward home while the nervous system stays at the office. The first people you see then meet the residue of the day.

The principle

You do not have to fake a good mood. You can notice what you are carrying, choose what belongs tomorrow, and decide how you want to enter before the door opens.

The practice: The parked car transition

Safety comes first. Set navigation before moving, keep the phone out of hand while driving, and do the exercise only after you are parked with the engine off.

01 Park and stop

Engine off. Phone silent and out of your hand. Give yourself two minutes before opening the door.

02 Name what followed you

Say or write the unfinished work, frustration, or worry that is still active. Decide what belongs to tomorrow.

03 Slow the exit

Take three slow breaths with a longer exhale. Let it mark the change from work to home.

04 Choose the entrance

Put the phone away. Make eye contact. Say hello like you mean it. Let the first ten seconds say that you have arrived.



Remote worker: close the laptop, step outside, and return through a different door. Transit or walking: use a landmark near home as the transition point.

Whoever is inside gets to know this is happening, otherwise two minutes in a parked car reads as avoidance. Say it once: if I sit out there a minute, I am not hiding, I am arriving.

The Driveway Card · Where it lives: The glovebox, because that is where the two minutes happen. Print it from the Resource Pack and put it where the moment happens.

Before your next drive, set navigation and put the phone where you cannot reach it. Do the Driveway Pause only after the car is fully parked.

The Driveway Pause is one of the first practices I built for myself. I needed a small space between being responsible for work and being available at home.

What part of my workday most often walks through the door with me?

LEAD · LESSON 2.1

The Emotional Thermostat

Pause before pressure chooses your response.

A familiar scene

The question is small, but it reaches you at the wrong moment. Your answer comes out sharper than you meant it to. Everyone hears the edge before anyone knows what kind of day you had, and the whole evening begins organizing itself around that tone.

What is happening

Pressure can make a person louder, colder, or absent. The people around them notice the change before they understand the reason. Pretending to be calm does not help, but neither does handing everyone else an unfiltered reaction.

The principle

Your mood sets the temperature for everyone around you, whether you mean it to or not. Nobody stays perfectly calm. The practice is noticing earlier, taking a clean pause, and repairing honestly after a miss.

The practice: Pause, return, repair

Use the shortest response that keeps a hard moment from becoming a larger one.

01 Pause before the answer

Change your body before you try to change your mind. Stand up, step into another room or outside, and take three breaths with a longer exhale. Sixty seconds. If you can respond respectfully after that, do it. If not, say that you need a short break.

02 Name the return time

Say when you will come back, then keep your word. That is what keeps a pause from feeling like you left. Choose a specific time, even if it is ten minutes away.

03 Return with one calm sentence

Start with what is true and useful. Do not open with a defense, a lecture, or a list of everything the other person did wrong.



If you were sharp or shut down, name it without an excuse. Apologize for your part and ask what would help reconnect.

If a conversation is unsafe, escalating, or beyond what a short pause can hold, step away and seek appropriate outside support. This practice is not a substitute for therapy or crisis help.

Agree on the pause before you need it, when nothing is wrong. A break called mid argument by someone who never mentioned it sounds like walking out. A break you both named last Tuesday sounds like the plan working.

Pause, Return, Repair · Where it lives: The nightstand. Print it from the Resource Pack and put it where the moment happens.

Write the sentence you can use next time: I am too worked up to answer well. I will come back at ____.

I do not always catch the moment in time. That is why repair matters. Looking composed was never the goal. Taking responsibility and coming back is.

When pressure rises, do I get louder, quieter, more controlling, or more distant?

LEAD · LESSON 2.2

The Date Night Experiment

Create a little curiosity together.

A familiar scene

You finally get time together and spend the first twenty minutes deciding where to go. At dinner, both phones keep appearing beside the plates. Nothing is wrong, exactly. The night just feels like another familiar task instead of a chance to notice each other again.

What is happening

A date can become another logistical task or a familiar routine where both people are still half inside work and phones. Usually the activity is fine. What gets in the way is divided attention and expectations nobody said out loud.

The principle

Try something new, do it side by side, and keep the phones out of it. Treat each date as an experiment: notice something together, choose together, and give the time a clear boundary.

The practice: Choose, protect, notice

Plan one experience that fits your money, energy, mobility, childcare, and actual life.

01 Choose together

Each person offers two ideas. Pick one that feels possible, not impressive. A walk somewhere new can work as well as an expensive night out.

02 Put the phones away

Silence them and place them out of sight before you sit down. Allow priority contacts if needed, then agree that either person can check only for a real reason.

03 Do something alongside each other

Cook a new meal, visit a new place, take a class, build something, play a game, or explore a part of town you usually pass.

04 Notice, do not grade

Ask what felt easy, interesting, or worth doing again. The night does not have to prove anything about your relationship.



Use an at home, free, low cost, sensory friendly, or mobility friendly version. Twenty intentional minutes can count when a full evening cannot.

Two ideas each, pick one, phones in the glovebox before you sit down. Afterwards ask what was interesting, not whether it worked. A night that has to prove something about your relationship stops being a night out.

The Date Night Card · Where it lives: The wallet, so the idea survives the week. Print it from the Resource Pack and put it where the moment happens.

At the next weekly check in, each of you brings two possible dates, chooses one real time, and agrees where the silenced phones will stay.

Forget the perfect date. What helps is getting out of autopilot long enough to experience something together.

What kind of shared activity makes conversation feel easier for us?

LEAD · LESSON 2.3

The Floor General

Join their world without taking it over.

A familiar scene

Your child says your name, asks a question, or calls, Watch this. They look for your eyes before they look for an answer. If the phone gets the first response, the small invitation can close before either of you realizes what happened.

What is happening

Parents can spend a whole evening near their children while attention remains divided. A repeated downward glance can make the screen feel like it arrived first, even when that is not what the parent means. Even well meant play can become another adult led agenda where the child is managed instead of met.

The principle

The parent creates the safe conditions. The child leads the play or conversation. The floor is a way of saying join their world. You do not have to sit in one position.

The practice: Eyes first, then follow

Answer the bid for connection before you do anything else. Put the phone away, get physically or emotionally near, and follow instead of directing.

01 Give them your eyes first

Set the phone down, make eye contact, and answer the invitation. If you cannot stop yet, say exactly when you can and keep that promise.

02 Enter their level

Sit on the floor, beside them, across the table, or in the passenger seat. Choose the position that works for both bodies and sensory needs.

03 Let them choose

Ask what they want to do or talk about. Resist improving the game, teaching a lesson, or steering toward your preferred activity.

04 End cleanly

Follow their cues, keep physical play safe and easy to stop, then give a brief warning when time is almost up. Say what you enjoyed and when you can return.

Make it fit

Use five minutes on a crowded day. For teens, drive, cook, fix, fish, walk, or work beside them without turning every silence into an interview.

If there are no kids in the house

If there are none, the practice does not change, only who it points at. Your partner makes bids for attention the same way a child does, just quieter and easier to miss: a story about their day, something read aloud, a hand on your shoulder on the way past. Answer the bid before you do anything else. Put the phone in another room rather than face down. Let them pick the subject and resist improving it, solving it, or turning it into logistics. Fifteen minutes where they lead and you follow. The thing a child does loudly, an adult does once and then stops asking.

Do it together

Cover for each other. Fifteen minutes on the floor only happens if someone else is holding the rest of the evening, and it should trade back the next night.

YOUR SHEET · 2.3

Floor Time · Where it lives: The kid's room, or the nightstand if there are none. Print it from the Resource Pack and put it where the moment happens.

Try this week

The next time your child calls your name or says, Watch this, set the phone down, meet their eyes, and answer before you return to anything else.

FROM CHRIS

I called it Floor General, but the lesson is mostly about giving up command. I set the conditions. They show me where connection is possible.

QUESTION TO SIT WITH

When I enter my child's world, how quickly do I start directing it?

KEEP · LESSON 3.1

The Third Place

Keep one part of life from becoming only work and home duty.

A familiar scene

Someone asks what you do for fun and you begin listing things you used to do. The bike needs air, the fishing gear has not moved, and the friend you meant to call is still a name in your phone. You are useful to everyone and quietly becoming unfamiliar to yourself.

What is happening

A person can become useful to everyone and still feel absent from their own life. Work and home both matter, but neither should have to carry every part of identity, play, friendship, and renewal.

The principle

Sociologist Ray Oldenburg used third place for social spaces outside home and work. All the Way Here uses that idea more broadly: a recurring place or activity where you can show up without performing your main roles.

The practice: Choose one recurring place

It should restore more than it distracts and fit fairly into the life you share with other people.

01 Name what restores you

Think beyond a generic self care checklist. It might be a trail, church, a workshop, fishing water, kettlebells, volunteering, a rec league, a breakfast table, or time making something.

02 Choose the smallest real version

Start with a recurring thirty minute block if that is what fits. A place becomes meaningful through return, not through dramatic amounts of time.

03 Coordinate at home

Protect restorative time for both of you. Put it on the shared calendar and account for childcare, money, and the rest each person needs.

04 Notice what it produces

Ask whether you return more alive and available or merely numbed and avoidant. Adjust honestly.



Some seasons require a smaller or closer version. Some problems require workload changes, sleep, medical care, therapy, or other support. A hobby is not a cure for burnout.

Put both on the calendar in the same conversation or this becomes one person's hobby and the other person's resentment. Equal time, agreed out loud, childcare counted honestly.

The Third Place · Where it lives: The bag you already carry. Print it from the Resource Pack and put it where the moment happens.

Choose one place or activity you want to return to twice this month and coordinate the first time.

Mountain biking, fishing, kettlebells, and riding are not credentials. They are places where I remember I am a person before I return to the people who need me.

Where do I feel like a whole person rather than only a worker, partner, or parent?

KEEP · LESSON 3.2

The Friendship Script

Invite first, and make the invitation easy to answer.

A familiar scene

You have known this person for three years. You talk at the game, the gym, church, or school pickup and always say you should get together. Neither of you is rejecting the other. The friendship is simply waiting for someone to name a day and a time.

What is happening

Many adult friendships remain vague. Two people may like and respect each other for years without either one naming a time, an activity, or the next invitation. Waiting for friendship to happen keeps it theoretical.

The principle

Friendship usually grows through specific invitations, shared activity, low stakes, and repetition. One or two dependable relationships can matter more than a large network.

The practice: The specific invitation

Choose a person, an activity, and a time. Keep the first invitation simple enough that a no does not become a verdict on the relationship.

01 Pick one person

Choose someone you respect or already enjoy being around. You do not need to decide whether they will become a close friend.

02 Make it concrete

Try: I am riding Saturday at eight. Want to come? Or: I am grabbing coffee after the kids' game. Join me?

03 Repeat without chasing

Schedules are real. Invite again later if the first answer is no or uncertain. Respect a pattern of disinterest without turning it into a personal failure.

04 Let honesty grow later

Start shoulder to shoulder. When trust exists, ask a real question and answer one honestly yourself.



If geography or health limits activity, use a recurring call, online game, project check in, or breakfast. Repetition matters more than the setting.

Protect each other's friendships the way you protect your own. A relationship asked to be the only close one either of you has will buckle under a job neither of you gave it.

The Friendship Script · Where it lives: The wallet. Print it from the Resource Pack and put it where the moment happens.

Send one specific, low pressure invitation before the day ends.

I do not need a giant network. I need a few people I can call, and that begins with being willing to invite someone.

Who do I keep hoping will invite me, and what stops me from inviting them first?

KEEP · LESSON 3.3

Mission Debrief

Keep the practices that helped.

A familiar scene

The final lesson is open, the notes look good, and real life is already interrupting. This is the point where a course usually becomes another completed file. Instead of collecting nine ideas, you choose the two that deserve to live past this screen.

What is happening

A course can become another pile of information. Finishing every page does not matter if none of the practices survive an ordinary week.

The principle

All the Way Here is about coming back, more than finishing. Choose the few practices that met a real problem, use them long enough to learn, and release the rest for now.

The practice: Two practices for thirty days

Look back at the Focus Protocol and the eight practices, and choose two. Make each one specific enough to use.

01 Name the real problem

What is costing you the most right now: unfinished mental load, reactive work, poor transitions, pressure, distance at home, or isolation?

02 Choose two practices

Pick one that helps you Return and one that helps you Lead or Keep. More is not automatically better.

03 Define the minimum

Write when, where, and how small the practice can become on a hard week without disappearing.

04 Review without a scorecard

After thirty days, ask what changed, what did not fit, and what you want to continue. Do not turn family life into a compliance dashboard.



If a practice creates conflict, shame, or more management than value, stop and redesign it. Use professional help when the problem is beyond the scope of educational material.

Choose two practices between you, not nine. Write them where you both see them. In thirty days, ask what happened. Nobody is grading either of you.

The Thirty Day Page · Where it lives: The table, next to the board sheet. Print it from the Resource Pack and put it where the moment happens.

Open the course book and circle the two practices you will use for the next thirty days.

Keep the two things that helped. The rest will be here when you need it.

Which two practices would make the biggest difference in the life I am already living?

THE RESOURCE PACK

Tools that live where life happens.

This book is the place to learn and write. The sheets stay separate on purpose: print the one you need and put it where the practice happens. They all come in one file, the Resource Pack, so you can print the whole kit at once. Card sheets print four to a page: cut on the dashed lines.

START	The Focus Protocol The four moves and what each stretch of the three days feels like.	The fridge
WEEKLY	The Sunday Board Meeting The shared week on the front, your own week on the back. Free to anyone.	The table
1.1	The Brain Dump Print one a week.	The desk
1.2	Tomorrow Matters If Filled in the night before.	The desk
1.3	The Driveway Card Four to a page. One for each car.	The glovebox
2.1	Pause, Return, Repair Agree on it before you need it.	The nightstand
2.2	The Date Night Card So the idea survives the week.	The wallet
2.3	Floor Time Has a version for couples with no kids.	The kid's room
3.1	The Third Place One each. Both on the calendar.	The bag
3.2	The Friendship Script Invite first.	The wallet
3.3	The Thirty Day Page The last thing you do in the course.	The table
CARD	The Field Card The whole course on one page.	The fridge or the car
FAMILY	Family tools Three optional pages for using the practices with kids.	Wherever the family is

KEEP · THE LAST PAGE

Keep the parts that held up.

Do not keep every practice just because you bought the course. Look back at the Focus Protocol and the nine practices, choose two that meet a problem you actually have, and give each a moment, a response, and a smallest version for the hard week. The Thirty Day Page in the Resource Pack is the same thing for the table.

There is no perfect finish. Notice sooner, repair faster, and keep coming back to the life in front of you.

THE TWO PRACTICES I AM KEEPING

THE MOMENT EACH PRACTICE IS FOR

THE SMALLEST VERSION I WILL STILL DO ON A HARD WEEK

WHAT I NOTICED ABOUT THE PEOPLE I SHARE LIFE WITH

WHAT WE WANT TO REVISIT IN THIRTY DAYS
